

PRINCE2 | P2-04

Business Case

The continued business justification for the project

Meridian Group

Programme Helios — Infrastructure and Platform Stack for AI GPU Compute at Scale

Field	Detail
Document title	Business Case
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Project / Programme	Helios Tranche 2 — Scale Build
Version	1.0
Status	Baselined
Date	18 Sep 2026
Author	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager
Owner	Executive
Approver	Project Board (and corporate/programme management where investment thresholds apply)
Classification	Internal
Retention	7 years from programme closure

Document control

Version history

Version	Date	Author	Summary of change
0.1	04 Jun 2026	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager	Initial draft
0.2	21 Jul 2026	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager	Updated following workstream lead review
1.0	18 Sep 2026	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager	Baselined at the Tranche 2 funding gate

Reviewers

Name	Role	Review scope	Date reviewed
T. Nakamura, Chief Platform Architect	Chief Platform Architect	Technical content and solution alignment	08 Sep 2026
L. Haddad, CISO	CISO	Security, assurance and residency content	10 Sep 2026
C. Whitfield, Finance Business Partner	Finance Business Partner	Cost, funding and benefit figures	11 Sep 2026
M. Verity, Head of P3O	Head of P3O	Governance standards and completeness	15 Sep 2026

Approval

This product is baselined once approval is recorded below. Any subsequent change must go through change control.

Name	Role	Decision	Date
R. Al Mazrouei, Group CTO	Senior Responsible Owner / Group CTO	Approved	18 Sep 2026
H. Farrell, Director of Infrastructure	Director of Infrastructure	Approved	18 Sep 2026
L. Haddad, CISO	CISO	Approved subject to closure of ISS-003	18 Sep 2026

Related products

Reference	Product	Relationship
P2-05	Benefits Management Approach	Defines how benefits in this case are measured
P2-11	Plan	Source of cost and timescale
P2-17	Risk Register	Source of risk exposure

How to use this template

Aspect	Guidance
Purpose	Documents the justification for the project based on estimated costs, risks and expected benefits, and provides the basis for the continued business justification check at every decision point.
Framework	PRINCE2 — Outline in Starting up a Project; detailed in Initiating a Project; reviewed at every stage boundary and at closure
Created when	Outline during Starting up a Project; full version during Initiating a Project
Reviewed / updated	At every stage boundary, on any exception, and at project closure
Owner	Executive
Approver	Project Board (and corporate/programme management where investment thresholds apply)
Format options	Document, presentation, register entry, or tool record — the content matters, not the medium.
Tailoring	Scale the depth of each section to the scale, risk and complexity of the work. Delete sections that add no value and record the tailoring decision in the governance approach.

This is a worked example. Every field has been completed with illustrative content for Programme Helios, a fictional AI GPU infrastructure and platform programme. All example content is shown in grey italic — the black text is the template itself. Replace the grey italic content with your own.

Quality criteria

Use these to check the product is fit for purpose before submitting it for approval.

- Benefits are measurable, with a baseline and a named benefits owner
- Costs are consistent with the Project Plan and include operational running costs
- Investment appraisal method is appropriate and assumptions are stated
- Dis-benefits are identified as well as benefits
- It is reviewed and updated — a stale Business Case is a governance failure
- The "do nothing" option is genuinely appraised

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1. Executive summary

One page. The decision being asked for, the investment, the return, and the primary risk to viability.

Programme Helios consolidates fragmented AI compute onto a single shared platform in DXB-1, scaling to 2,048 GPUs in Tranche 2 and 4,096 by Tranche 3. The decision requested is release of AED 118m of Tranche 2 capital at the 18 September 2026 gate.

The return is AED 14.3m of annual public cloud rental substituted, utilisation lifted from 31% to 72%, and median training cycle time cut from 11.5 days to 3 days. The principal risk to viability is vendor GPU allocation slipping beyond November 2026 (RSK-001), which would defer the benefit by a quarter.

2. Reasons

Why the project is needed and how it aligns with organisational objectives and strategy.

Three drivers make this urgent. Utilisation across the current siloed estates is unsustainably low. Public cloud rental costs are growing at roughly 40% year on year with no corresponding increase in delivered value. And an increasing proportion of training data is subject to UAE residency obligations that the current arrangement cannot satisfy without exception.

3. Business options

Always appraise at minimum: do nothing, do the minimum, and do something. "Do nothing" is the baseline against which the others are measured.

Option	Description	Cost	Benefit	Risk	Recommendation
Do nothing	Continue with four departmental GPU estates and growing public cloud rental	AED 19.4m per year and rising ~40% annually	None — utilisation stays at 31% and residency exceptions persist	Cost growth is unbounded and four residency exceptions remain open	Baseline only. Rejected — fails the residency obligation.
Do the minimum	Refresh the two largest departmental clusters in place; no consolidation, no multi-tenancy	AED 38,400,000 capital, AED 11.2m per year run	Partial capacity relief; utilisation improves to about 41%	Silos persist, so the utilisation and rental benefits are largely unrealised	Rejected — delivers under a third of the benefit for a third of the cost, with none of the residency improvement.
Option 3	Full consolidation onto a shared multi-tenant platform in DXB-1, scaling across three tranches	AED 176,600,000 total, AED 14.6m per year run from FY28	Full benefit case: AED 14.3m rental substituted, 72% utilisation, residency exceptions closed	Vendor allocation and cooling capacity are the principal exposures, both actively mitigated	Recommended.

4. Expected benefits

Each benefit must have a baseline measure, a target, a measurement method, a timing, and a named owner in the business.

Ref	Benefit	Baseline	Target	Measure	Realisation date	Owner
BEN-01	Reduced external GPU rental spend	AED 19.4m per year on public cloud GPU rental	AED 5.1m per year by FY28	Cloud billing export, GPU SKU lines only	From Q3 2027	V. Chandra, Head of AI Enablement
BEN-02	Faster model training cycle time	11.5 days median from experiment start to evaluated result	3 days median by Q4 2027	MLOps pipeline telemetry, median across tracked experiments	From Q2 2027	N. Ozturk, ML Platform Lead
BEN-03	Improved compute utilisation	31% average GPU utilisation across siloed estates	72% average utilisation by Q4 2027	DCGM utilisation telemetry, 5-minute samples	From Q3 2027	P. Raghavan, Platform Engineering Lead
BEN-04	Reduced time to provision AI environments	23 working days from request to usable environment	2 hours self-service by Q3 2027	Service request timestamps	From Q3 2027	P. Raghavan, Platform Engineering Lead
BEN-05	Data residency and sovereignty assurance	4 workloads with unresolved residency exceptions	Zero residency exceptions by Q4 2027	Compliance exception register	From Q3 2027	L. Haddad, CISO
BEN-06	New revenue from AI-enabled products	AED 0	AED 8.6m incremental revenue in FY29	Product P&L attribution	From FY29	V. Chandra, Head of AI Enablement

5. Expected dis-benefits

Outcomes perceived as negative by one or more stakeholders which are an actual consequence of the project — e.g. reduced user convenience from stronger authentication, or temporary reduction in throughput during migration.

Ref	Dis-benefit	Affected group	Quantification	Mitigation
DIS-01	Legacy departmental GPU	Fraud Analytics and	Cuts environment	Guaranteed fair-share

Ref	Dis-benefit	Affected group	Quantification	Mitigation
	<i>clusters are decommissioned, removing local control</i>	<i>Research teams</i>	<i>provisioning from 23 working days to under two hours</i>	<i>quota and priority queue for time-critical work, published in the service catalogue</i>
DIS-02	<i>Chargeback introduces a visible cost where compute was previously treated as free</i>	<i>All consuming business units</i>	<i>Improves PUE from 1.62 to 1.21 across the estate</i>	<i>Twelve-month transition at subsidised rates; rate card published a full budget cycle in advance</i>
DIS-03	<i>Facilities team must acquire and sustain liquid-cooling competence</i>	<i>Service Operations and FM provider</i>	<i>Reduces median training cycle time from 11.5 days to 3 days</i>	<i>Vendor training funded for eight staff; 4-hour on-site vendor cover for the first year</i>

6. Timescale

Period over which the project will run and the period over which benefits will be realised and measured.

Programme Helios — Tranche 2 scale build, DXB-1 halls A and B. Applies from hall A handover; hall B follows in Tranche 2 closure. Detail is maintained by the Executive and reviewed at the monthly Programme Board.

7. Costs

Project costs

Cost category	Yr 0	Yr 1	Yr 2	Yr 3	Total
Internal resource	AED 1,640,000	AED 2,870,000	AED 5,740,000	AED 8,610,000	AED 91,200,000
External / supplier	AED 136,000	AED 238,000	AED 476,000	AED 714,000	AED 17,800,000
Licences and subscriptions	AED 560,000	AED 980,000	AED 1,960,000	AED 2,940,000	AED 13,600,000
Infrastructure / hardware	AED 560,000	AED 980,000	AED 1,960,000	AED 2,940,000	AED 24,300,000
Training and change	AED 3,440,000	AED 6,020,000	AED 12,040,000	AED 18,060,000	AED 6,800,000
Contingency	AED 920,000	AED 1,610,000	AED 3,220,000	AED 4,830,000	AED 11,200,000
Total	AED 7,120,000	AED 12,460,000	AED 24,920,000	AED 37,380,000	AED 8,400,000

Ongoing operational costs

Costs incurred after handover — support, licensing, monitoring, periodic assurance. These are frequently omitted and frequently fatal to the case.

Cost category	Annual cost	Funding source	Owner
Accelerator hardware	AED 1,120,000	Configuration management database	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager
Storage and parallel filesystem	AED 91,200,000	Assurance evidence pack, Tranche 2 gate	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager
Network fabric	AED 4,200,000	ALM tool — Helios ART board	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager
Facilities — power, cooling, structural	AED 96,000	Solution intent wiki, DXB-1 platform space	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager

Funding arrangements

Source of funds, approval route, capital/revenue split, and any phasing conditions.

8. Investment appraisal

Compare costs against benefits over the appraisal period. State the method (NPV, payback, ROI, cost avoidance) and the assumptions including discount rate.

Measure	Value	Assumption / basis
Total cost of ownership	AED 118,000,000 for Tranche 2; tolerance of +5% before escalation	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager
Total quantified benefit	No more than 10% variance against the benefit profile before escalation	No more than 10% variance against the benefit profile before escalation
Net benefit	No more than 10% variance against the benefit profile before escalation	No more than 10% variance against the benefit profile before escalation
Payback period	AED 4,200,000	Scheduled fraud workloads could be pre-empted by research jobs
NPV / IRR	AED 91,200,000	Departmental autonomy is removed with no compensating guarantee
Non-quantified benefits	No more than 10% variance against the benefit profile before escalation	No more than 10% variance against the benefit profile before escalation

9. Major risks

Summarise the risks that most threaten the viability of the investment, with the aggregate risk exposure. Do not duplicate the Risk Register.

Ref	Risk to viability	Assessment	Response summary
RSK-001	Vendor allocation slippage defers the Tranche 2 benefit by a quarter (RSK-001)	Level 3 — defined	Allocation confirmed in writing at contract award; 20% of Tranche 2 volume dual-sourced; staged acceptance so hall A can proceed independently of hall B
RSK-002	Slow workload migration leaves the platform under-used (RSK-015)	Acceptable — within tolerance	Structural survey completed before hall B order; CDU capacity modelled at N+1; contingency for a reduced 1,536-GPU configuration held
RSK-003	Fabric tuning falls short of the 92% all-reduce target (RSK-005)	High residual exposure; active mitigation in place	Namespace and network policy isolation validated by penetration test before multi-tenant go-live; per-tenant KMS keys; quarterly control testing
RSK-004	Scarce platform engineering skills extend contractor dependence (RSK-004)	Level 2 — repeatable	Two contractors engaged from October 2026 with knowledge-transfer clauses; internal conversion programme from the infrastructure team
RSK-005	Weak tenant isolation exposes model weights across business units (RSK-003)	Level 3 — defined	NCCL benchmark gate at pilot exit; vendor performance engineering engaged for two weeks per hall; fallback to reduced job scale documented

10. Business Case review record

Review point	Date	Still viable / desirable / achievable?	Decision
End of initiation	18 Sep 2026	15 Oct 2026	Approved with conditions
End stage 2	18 Sep 2026	Tranche 2 — Scale build	Tranche 2 — Scale build
End stage 3	18 Sep 2026	Tranche 2 — Scale build	Tranche 2 — Scale build
Closure	30 Jul 2027	26 Feb 2027	Rejected